In Raúl Castro's first few months in office he proposed various economic steps that excited much commentary both at home and abroad. One set of reforms sought to stimulate agricultural production by offering incentives to small farmers, including leasing state land to private farmers, and raising state prices for agricultural goods. Access to computers, video recorders, and cell phones, previously restricted, was opened, and Cubans were granted entry to tourist hotels. Raúl called on Cubans to openly discuss the country's political and economic problems. "Fidel cannot be replaced unless all of us replace him together," he told Havana university students, signaling what many Cubans saw as a shift to a less personalistic and more collective style of leadership.[43] He also announced that a Party Congress would be held in 2009 – the first since 1997, and the sixth since 1959. "If Fidel were still President and he was the one announcing the congress, I think most people would yawn," said one Cuba watcher. "But for Raul, it's saying, 'By the end of next year we're going to face the music and put forth a record.' "[44]

Ten U.S. Presidents, beginning with Dwight D. Eisenhower, had sought to remove Fidel Castro from office and overturn the Cuban Revolution. Only months after Fidel ceded the presidency, Barack Obama was elected President of the United States, promising "change."

Even Cuban Americans – traditionally the group most resistant to any opening towards Cuba – were changing. A poll conducted a month after Obama's election showed that 55 percent of Cubans in south Florida supported ending the embargo, and 65 percent wanted to see diplomatic relations re-established.[45] This brought them close to the U.S. population as a whole, which by a 71 percent margin believed that diplomatic relations should be restored.[46]

At the Americas Summit in Trinidad only a few months into his term of office, Obama reiterated that "the United States seeks a new beginning with Cuba." His announcement that he was lifting Bush-era restrictions on Cuban American travel to the island and remittances, and was ready to discuss restoring direct mail and a new accord on migration, was welcomed by many Cubans and Cuban Americans. This did not, however, constitute a new beginning. Although his